

A PRABHAKAR RAO



NAIDU (SECOND FROM RIGHT) WITH OTHER MEMBERS OF THE ILL-FATED GRAND ALLIANCE

he could not avoid accommodating different interests and groups to reinforce the perception that the Congress is open to everyone, notwithstanding its image of a Reddy dominant party.

In turning incumbency to his advantage, Reddy has relied heavily on the implementation of a slew of welfare programmes. "I have relied on the model of convergence of schemes so as to ensure that every eligible family is covered by one or more welfare and poverty alleviation measure," Reddy told INDIA TODAY. He has relied on the saturation concept of covering as many families as possible through the development and dole programmes to make doubly sure that every family benefits in more than one way.

There is Rajiv Aarogyasri which offers a state-sponsored health insurance cover, the *pavala vaddi* scheme which entitles women who are members of the self-help groups to borrow at the low interest rate of 3 per cent, the *Abhaya Hastham*—the pioneering co-contributory pension scheme for 1.25 crore women members of self-help groups—

YSR HAS SUCCESSFULLY DESTROYED A 30-YEAR-OLD JINX THAT PREVENTED THE CONGRESS FROM WINNING SUCCESSIVE ELECTIONS AS THE RULING PARTY IN ANDHRA PRADESH.

and CPI(M) as well as the TRS to form the 'mahakutami' (Grand Alliance). Even that failed to give Naidu the cutting edge though it helped improve his party's position from 47 to 92. But his electoral allies paid a heavier price to win fewer seats than they did in 2004.

Reddy's strength is his organisational ability. Ignoring other party rivals, he planned the party's campaign, described as the Congress Prachara Jaitra Yatra, which covered 170 of the 294 constituencies, and announced the party's list of contestants early so as to give them and the party a headstart. It is also the first time that the party had announced the names at one go after an elaborate exercise by Reddy's brain trust, steered by his confidant and medical college classmate Dr K.V.P. Ramachandra Rao, to pick contestants based on a SWOT analysis of both the constituency as well as the contestant. In the process, Reddy dropped as many as 50 sitting legislators and replaced many with younger Congress aspirants. If he had his way, some of the 10 ministers who lost may not have been given tickets but

which entitles them to get a monthly pension from the day they turn 60, houses for the poor under the Indiramma scheme and a host of doles including scholarships and pensions. He also gave 4 per cent reservation for minorities and increased the spending on scholarships for them from Rs 4 crore to Rs 37 crore.

Jalayagnam, intended to irrigate drylands, though mired in controversies about kickbacks being paid by contractors to ruling party politicians, is an ambitious mission launched by YSR to improve the rural connect of the Congress. The mission is to build 78 dams with a massive investment of Rs 1.8 lakh crore. Of this, more than Rs 40,000 crore has been pumped in so far, 12 projects have been completed and irrigation provided to 18 lakh acres.

At the same time, he tapped Central government sponsored schemes like the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme with innovations like smart cards issued to beneficiaries to ensure better targeting and fostered grievance hearing mechanisms like setting up the Andhra Pradesh Information Commission to implement the Right to Information Act and even constitute the